

“As consumers, we all have ‘secret scores’” (Hill, 2019). According to Kashmir Hill, author of *The New York Times* (NYT) article, “I Got Access to My Secret Consumer Score,” these scores determine the time someone waits on hold, what items a person can return at a store, and the quality of service received. What is worse, these scores are largely inaccessible. This topic was featured in chapter eight of Cathy O’Neil’s (2016) book, “Weapons of Math Destruction.” O’Neil reviewed an article by Natasha Singer from the *NYT* titled, “Secret E-Scores Chart Consumers’ Buying Power.” She argues data brokers and businesses collect personal information behind the scenes and sell this information to businesses for marketing purposes. Hill’s piece will be the focus of my deep dive, as it explores the topic further.

In the *NYT* article, Hill reviews a copy her consumer report from a company called Sift (<https://sift.com/>). Sift had access to messages Hill sent to Airbnb, Yelp posts she wrote, app metrics from her iPhone (e.g., how many times she opened certain apps). Hill’s (2019) report was “More than 400 pages long.” According to Hill, the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA) was the reason she had access to this information. “Set to go into effect in 2020, the law will grant Californians the right to see what data a company holds on them” she wrote. Her entries in the report did not include scores but did include a “percentage rating” for each entry designating it as “abuse,” “normal,” or “fraud,” among other ratings. According to Sift’s home page, the company leverages machine learning and user insights to combat fraud for companies such as DoorDash, Yelp, and Poshmark (Sift Science, Inc., 2025). Sift boasts that “Over 1T (trillion) annual events from 34K+ sites and apps feed [their] global data network” (Sift Science, Inc., 2025).

O’Neil referenced a *Wall Street Journal* article (Palazzolo & Fields, 2015) on background checks that used similar services. O’Neil noted that a Philadelphia resident, Helen Stokes, was denied residence at a senior living facility because a company, RealPage, Inc., provided a report to the landlord showing two previous arrests that had been expunged from Stokes’ record. Stokes ended up suing RealPage, Inc. to get the information removed. O’Neil described the record as “poisonous misinformation” (2016, p. 151). Technically speaking, this is not misinformation. Stokes was arrested. The arrest was expunged and should not have been included in the report. Nevertheless, this practice is problematic.

In this class, we have read thought pieces about data ethics, and we have been treated to much chin stroking on the use of consumer data. But none of our readings have made salient the way in which data is used and just how creepy it is. Knowing that Apple tracks what apps and the number of times I open them, the screen time usage (settings > screen time), and who knows what else. I was already on board with the need to restrict access to consumer data, but this reaffirms it. It seems to me data this detailed should not be sold, and what data is sold must have an expiration date (e.g., must be deleted after one year).

References

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